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MEL 101: Introduction to Modern European Languages

French and German foundations: sounds, gender and basic structures

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Modern European Languages | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

This pack covers the first-semester foundations of French and German: pronunciation and silent letters, articles and gender, basic verb conjugation, word order, and the study habits that make a foreign language stick. It also explains how to use a dictionary properly.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Pronounce basic French and German sounds accurately.
- Use definite and indefinite articles with correct gender.
- Conjugate common verbs in the present tense.
- Build correct simple sentences in each language.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Sounds and spelling

Spelling and sound diverge; learn both together.

- French: nasal vowels, liaisons and silent final consonants.
- French: accent marks affect pronunciation and meaning.
- German: umlauts, the ich and ach sounds, and final devoicing.
- German: nouns are capitalised; compounds carry meaning in parts.
- Read aloud daily; silent reading builds no pronunciation.
- Use audio from the start rather than translating word by word.

Gender, articles and agreement

Gender is grammatical, not logical.

- French: le, la, les; un, une, des.
- German: der, die, das; ein, eine, ein; cases change articles.
- Adjectives agree with the noun in gender and number.
- Word order: German places the finite verb second in main clauses.
- Negation patterns differ from English; learn them as whole phrases.
- Record nouns with their article from the first day.

> **Learn the article with the noun**
> Memorising 'Tisch' without 'der' guarantees errors later. Learn 'der Tisch' as one item.

Study routine and resources

Language learning rewards frequency over intensity.

- Twenty minutes daily beats three hours once a week.
- Use spaced repetition for vocabulary with audio.
- Speak from week one, even imperfectly.
- Keep an error log and review it weekly.
- Read a dictionary entry properly: gender, part of speech, example.
- Watch/listen to authentic material with subtitles, then without.

Why a European language, and which one

Modern European languages are studied in Nigeria for practical and scholarly reasons: diplomatic and trade relations, access to scholarship, translation, tourism, and the comparative study of language itself. French is the most widely taught because of Nigeria's francophone neighbours and regional bodies; German, Spanish, Portuguese, Russian and Arabic-related programmes exist with smaller cohorts.

Learning a language is not learning a code of translations. It is learning a system with its own categories: gender in French and German, case in German and Russian, aspect in Russian, the subjunctive as a living mood in French and Spanish. These are not decoration; they change what must be said and what can be left unsaid.

The comparison with Nigerian languages is genuinely illuminating. Learners who speak a tonal language often find European stress patterns easier; learners whose first language lacks grammatical gender find noun gender the hardest feature; learners from a language without articles find French partitives puzzling.

The four skills and how to build them